



become more conscious of local produce. In the West you are used to going to a dairy and picking up fresh cheese. Here you are eating imported cheese out of a tin can and since our cold chain isn't the best, imported stuff faces those challenges as well, not to mention the carbon footprint."

Mehra, who is a food photographer, set up Spotted Cow in Mumbai in 2015 with his brother Agnay as a passion project in his basement. He

used to brew beer at home and wanted to pair good cheese but encountered the same problems as Narang. Today Spotted Cow ships pan India through their website and is also available in leading gourmet stores across the country. Their mozzarella and burrata are top sellers. They have also introduced a typically French ash-coated goat cheese. While most of these players focussed on institutional sales, the pandemic resulted in them changing

1. Käse started as a social enterprise to skill hearing-impaired girls. They also work with herding communities in Rajasthan and Gujarat

2. Spotted Cow doesn't believe in Indianising the cheese. Its tag line is 'Frightfully close to European style cheese'

3. Begum Victoria only uses responsibly-sourced A2 cow's milk

4. Darima has impacted a dozen villages through milk aggregation and women's empowerment

plans. Spotted Cow, for instance, earlier supplied 80 per cent of its produce to institutions but now retail and direct-to-consumer is growing significantly. Similarly, Eleftheria supplied 100 per cent to institutions but set up its website in 2020 and now ships across Mumbai and Pune. "We have our own fleet of delivery vans and we manage the last mile delivery ourselves. We take care of the integrity of the cheese," says Narang. For Darima too, nearly 80 per cent today is direct-to-consumer. "Covid-19 also changed the consumption trends. It really increased our engagement with customers directly. They were comfortable buying from brands that were more personalised instead of just supermarkets," says Shruti Golchha, Co-founder, Begum Victoria.

While customers are happy to have more variety of cheese available either at neighbourhood gourmet stores or delivered home, restaurateurs who work with artisanal cheese are also pleased. Mumbai-based The Bombay Canteen and O Pedro use cheese from Eleftheria and Begum Victoria. Says Hussain Shahzad, Executive Chef: "With artisanal cheese there is scope for evolution. For instance, a burrata can be handcrafted in a particular grammage as per my requirements."

On the other hand, Tarun Sibal, chef and restaurateur, Tiltle Goa and Street Storyss Bengaluru feels that "a Parmesan is a Parmesan, irreplaceable and so is the case with any GI-protected product." However, he adds that the local cheese produce has improved drastically and the space has livened up.

With more variety and accessibility, most of us are definitely saying 'cheese'. **BT**

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